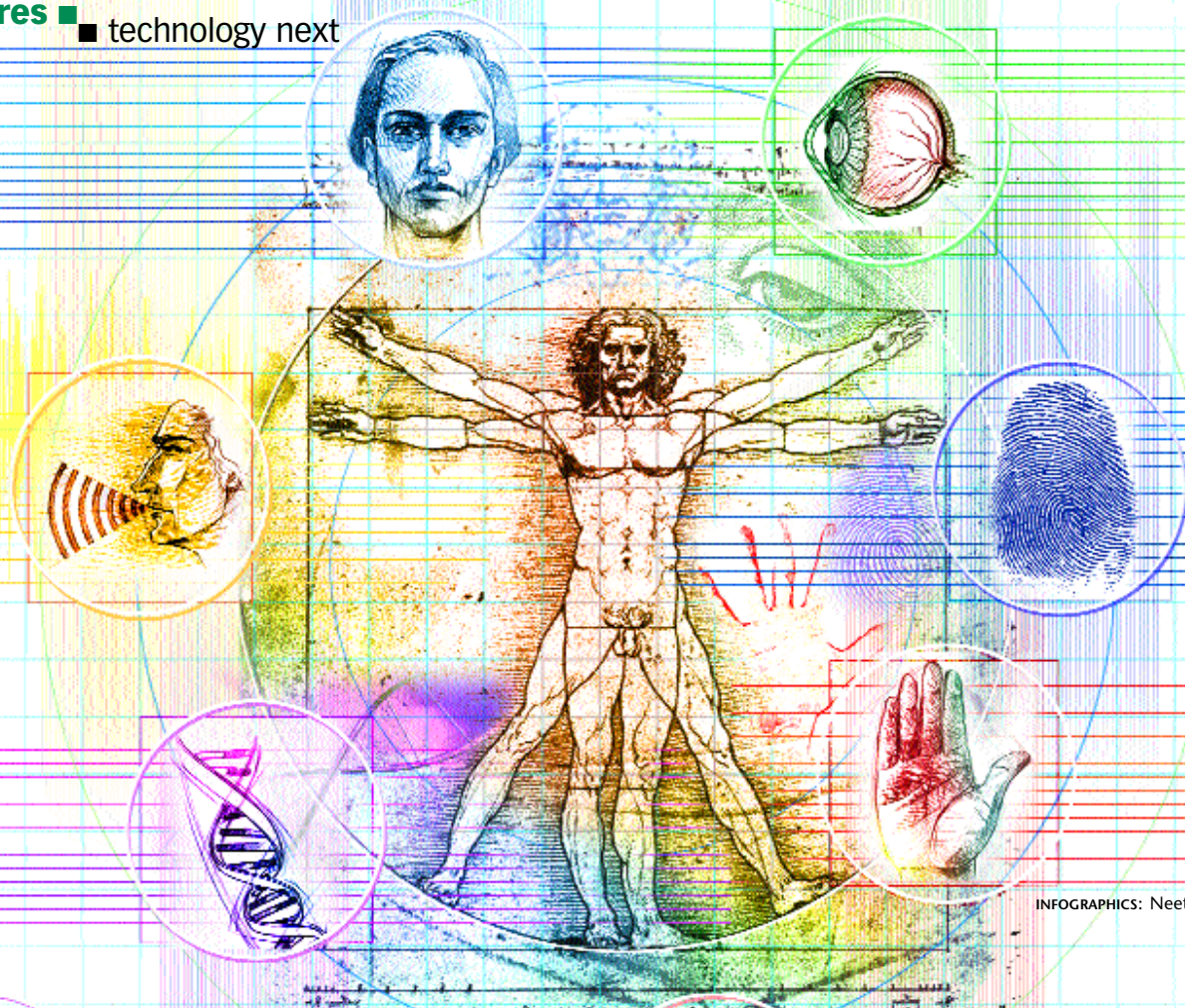




INFOGRAPHICS: Neeta Wadiker

Sense and Security

Passwords have been the means of authentication for too long. Long enough to allow development of virtually thousands of means to bypass security infrastructure. Biometrics promises to change the scene by introducing foolproof security measures. Or does it?

Walking into office, you flash your identification card at the security guard. He engages his face recognition system that identifies you and lets you pass. You later phone your colleague, who engages his voice-identification system to match your voice against an earlier recording, then gives you the information you need. After lunch you mark some bills with your personal bio-identification code and send them to accounts. They use their optical systems to scan your bio-code to clear those bills. In this high security office of the future, biometric systems are the primary means of identity authentication.

This hi-tech, high-security office of the future exists even today. Everyday, the security guard looks at your face and recognises you as an employee, your colleague hears your voice on the phone and knows it's you, and your signature assures people that you approve of what the paper says. Biological systems like us use biometrics everyday to identify each other. Now computers are able to do the same.

This opens up some significant security enhancements in the public space. For example, passports traditionally have a photograph and some identification marks described in them. Replace this with digital biometric data, and biometric security systems at airports could speed

up the checking process many times over, perform more accurate checks, and free up the security personnel for other tasks. Taking this into account, the U.K. government is looking to add fingerprint or iris data to all passports by the year 2006.

But that's not all, you can even have your own personal biometric systems that effectively replaces passwords. All the passwords you'll ever need to remember to use with your computer including login, Internet site passwords or e-mail would be hidden away behind your fingerprint. However, it is important to note that these systems work alongside passwords, not instead of them. You still need a login password for identification to let you access your files if the biometric

